

ABOUT THIS PROGRAM

Culture is **what a team does when no one is watching**. This short culture program helps you build a **strong team culture** in just **two sessions**, even when time is limited. It starts from one idea: **culture does not appear by itself, you build it on purpose**. In session 1, your players define **who they want to be as a team** and what promises they make to each other. In session 2, they learn how to **keep that culture alive when things get hard**, by being honest, holding each other accountable, and building in small rituals. **You as the coach are the key**: you guard the tone, set the example, and make sure agreements are not forgotten. The worksheets belong to the players, but **the direction comes from you**. Do not expect instant results, **culture grows over weeks and months**. The goal is not a perfect session, but **a team that feels ownership over its own behavior**. Use this guide as support, not as a script, and adapt it to your group.

GOALS OF THIS SESSION

- ✓ **Players name three values the team wants to show this season**
- ✓ **Players decide together what to keep as a team and what to let go**
- ✓ **Each player records a personal, signed promise to the team**

THE EXERCISES OF THIS SESSION

1. **Three words for our team** — ⌚ 10 min
2. **Culture anchors** — ⌚ 12 min
3. **Sign the team contract** — ⌚ 8 min

5 TIPS TO HELP YOUR TEAM IN THE SESSIONS

1. Go first: share your own answer before asking the players. Modeling vulnerability makes players more honest.
2. Let players write individually first (2 min), then share. This stops one loud voice from setting the tone for the whole group.
3. Do not judge any answer. A player who feels safe shares more than a player who feels evaluated.
4. Make everything concrete in behavior. For every vague answer ask: "What does that look like at practice?"
5. Close every session with one concrete agreement and a moment of quiet, so the meaning can settle.

WATCH OUT DURING THIS SESSION

- Do not let the discussion slide into complaining about last season. Redirect toward who you want to be.
- Never force anyone to share. Voluntary participation keeps safety high and answers honest.
- Guard the time: each exercise has a target time. Short and sharp beats long and vague.

RESEARCH BASIS (FOR REFERENCE)

- Cameron & Quinn (2011): teams that consciously name their culture perform more stably under pressure than teams that do not.
- Tod et al. (2011): public commitment, such as signing, increases adherence to behavioral agreements.
- Carron & Eys (2012): shared identity is the strongest predictor of team cohesion across a full season.

EXERCISES IN DETAIL

Everything per exercise, in order

1 Three words for our team

⌚ 10 min

EXPLAIN	Players make explicit what culture means to them in behavior. By starting individually before sharing, you avoid groupthink and everyone hears their own voice first.
SAY:	<i>"You have two minutes to write alone. No talking. Three words you want people to say about our team. Not about standings, but about our behavior and character."</i>
TIPS	- Go first: share your own words before asking the group. This normalizes vulnerability and raises the quality of their answers. - Link the chosen words to concrete moments: "When did you show this last year, and when did you not?" - Combine the most chosen words into three team words. Take a quick vote with a show of hands.
SCENARIOS	- Scenario A: almost everyone chooses the same word, e.g. "honesty". Ask: "When was that really there, and when did you miss it?" This brings the word to life instead of keeping it abstract. - Scenario B: players choose very different words. Say: "You choose different words but they all point to how you treat each other." Find the common thread together.
PITFALLS	- Moving too quickly to group discussion before everyone has written individually. Groupthink kills honesty. - Accepting words about results. "Champions" is not a culture word. Redirect to behavior: "How do you behave like a champion?"
FAQ	Q: Does it have to be exactly three words? A: No. If a player finds one perfect word, that is fine. It is about quality, not quantity. Q: What if players choose very different words? A: That is valuable. Show the differences and look together for what connects the words in behavior.

2 Culture anchors

⌚ 12 min

EXPLAIN	Teams that consciously name what they want to keep and let go break unhelpful behavior faster. The two columns make change concrete and steer the conversation forward.
SAY:	<i>"Think about last season. Left side: what do we want to keep as a team — behaviors, habits, moments. Right side: what do we consciously leave behind? Two minutes writing, then a short discussion."</i>
TIPS	- Redirect if "let go" becomes a complaint session. Ask: "What do we agree on so this is different this season?" - Make each item concrete in visible behavior: not "more discipline," but "we hold each other accountable when someone is late."
SCENARIOS	- Scenario A: a player wants to let go of "grumbling on the bench." Ask: "What do you do instead when you are frustrated?" This gives direction to the new behavior. - Scenario B: the group wants to let go of almost everything. Ask: "Was there really nothing positive last year?" This rebalances and gives recognition too.
PITFALLS	- Letting go becomes a complaint session instead of a forward look. Actively redirect if this happens. - Culture anchors stay vague. Help make each one concrete: "What does this look like as visible behavior at practice?"
FAQ	Q: How do you "let go" of something as a team concretely? A: By agreeing on a new behavior that replaces the old one. Not "less negativity," but "we build each other up after every mistake." Q: What if players disagree on what to let go? A: Let them briefly explain why they want to keep something. Then vote. The conversation itself is already valuable.

WRAPPING UP

Questions, follow-up and closing

3 Sign the team contract

⌚ 8 min

EXPLAIN	Public commitment through signing increases the chance that players actually follow through. A contract players wrote themselves works stronger than rules handed down from above.
SAY:	<i>"Write down three concrete promises you make to the team this season. Make them measurable: something you can check yourself. Then sign with name and date."</i>
TIPS	• Help players move from vague to concrete. "Work harder" → "I am the first to encourage a teammate after a mistake." • After writing, ask two players to read their promise out loud. This raises commitment for everyone. • Keep the contracts and bring them back midseason for an explicit check-in.
SCENARIOS	• Scenario A: a player writes a vague promise. Ask: "How will you know in three months if you did this?" Help make it more specific. • Scenario B: a player hesitates and writes nothing. Sit next to them: "What is one thing you want to contribute to this team this season?" Start small.
PITFALLS	• Accepting promises that cannot be checked. "I promise to be a better teammate" will fade within a week. • Forgetting to follow up on the contracts. A contract without follow-up is decoration. Plan the check-in now.
FAQ	Q: What if I do not keep my promise? A: That is human. What matters is that you acknowledge it and start again. Talk about it with your coach or a teammate. Q: Do I really have to write three promises? A: No. One strong, concrete promise is worth more than three vague ones. Quality matters more than quantity.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Which word did almost everyone choose, and what does that say about who you already are as a team?
2. What is personally hardest for you to let go of this season, and why?
3. Which promise do you dare to say out loud in front of the whole team?
4. How do you make sure this contract is not forgotten after today?

FOLLOW-UP IN THE COMING WEEKS

1. Keep the signed contracts and bring them back midseason: "What did you promise, and how is it going?"
2. Display the three culture words visibly in the locker room. Actively refer to them at evaluation moments.
3. In the coming week, name at least twice concrete behavior you observe that fits the culture anchors: "This is exactly what we meant."
4. Plan a check-in after six weeks: players reread their promise and score how well they kept it.

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GOALS OF THIS SESSION

- ✓ Players map how safe they feel in the team
- ✓ Players practice holding each other accountable without damaging the relationship
- ✓ Players choose rituals that keep the culture alive every week

THE EXERCISES OF THIS SESSION

1. **Trust barometer** — ⌚ 10 min
2. **The difficult conversation** — ⌚ 12 min
3. **Rituals and culture promise** — ⌚ 10 min

5 TIPS TO HELP YOUR TEAM IN THE SESSIONS

1. Go first: share your own answer before asking the players. Modeling vulnerability makes players more honest.
2. Let players write individually first (2 min), then share. This stops one loud voice from setting the tone for the whole group.
3. Do not judge any answer. A player who feels safe shares more than a player who feels evaluated.
4. Make everything concrete in behavior. For every vague answer ask: "What does that look like at practice?"
5. Close every session with one concrete agreement and a moment of quiet, so the meaning can settle.

WATCH OUT DURING THIS SESSION

- The trust barometer can be sensitive after a hard period. Listen first, ask questions later.
- Do not skip modeling the "I see, I feel, I ask" exercise. Players need to see the format before they try it.
- Keep rituals small. A ritual that feels like a burden disappears within two weeks.

RESEARCH BASIS (FOR REFERENCE)

- Edmondson (1999): psychological safety is a strong predictor of team performance under uncertainty.
- Eys et al. (2015): the "I see, I feel, I ask" model reduces aggressive language in conversations.
- Lencioni (2002): conflict avoidance is a team dysfunction. Healthy conflict is a sign of trust.

EXERCISES IN DETAIL

Everything per exercise, in order

1 Trust barometer

⌚ 10 min

EXPLAIN	Players make explicit how safe they feel in four concrete situations. This makes an invisible group dynamic visible and gives language to what would otherwise go unspoken.
SAY:	<i>"Give an honest score from 1 to 10 for each situation. No right or wrong. No one has to show their scores if they do not want to. Two minutes to write."</i>
TIPS	• Calibrate first: "If 10 means you dare to share everything, what is a 5 for your team?" This gives scores more meaning. • Shift from diagnosis to action: if many score low, ask: "What needs to change for you to score one point higher?" • No one is required to show scores. Voluntary sharing makes it safer to be honest.
SCENARIOS	• Scenario A: almost everyone scores low on "daring to admit mistakes." Ask: "What makes this not feel safe here?" Look for the first small step, not the perfect solution. • Scenario B: one player openly shares a low score. Respond without judgment: "Thank you for sharing this. It helps us as a team." • Scenario C: the team just had a bad game. Expect low scores. Listen first, ask questions later.
PITFALLS	• Using the barometer to judge the team instead of as a starting point for conversation. • Encouraging players to show scores when the group does not feel safe enough yet. Compulsory sharing kills trust.
FAQ	Q: What if no one wants to share their scores? A: That is a signal. Discuss anonymously: "What needs to change so we can share this?" The process is more valuable than the numbers. Q: Are low scores bad? A: No. A low score that gets spoken out loud is an opportunity to grow. Scores that never get discussed are the real problem.

2 The difficult conversation

⌚ 12 min

EXPLAIN	Players practice a model that separates observation, feeling, and request from attack and accusation. This way they dare to have difficult conversations without them escalating.
SAY:	<i>"Model this yourself first with a fictional example. Then write: I SEE (observation without interpretation), I FEEL (what it does to you), I ASK YOU TO (one concrete action). No names needed."</i>
TIPS	• Always give a complete model example before letting players write. Everyone needs to know exactly what you expect. • Emphasize: I SEE is about facts, not judgments. "You are always late" is a judgment. "You were late to the last three practices by 10 minutes" is an observation. • After writing, ask if anyone wants to read their text out loud. Allow anonymity if that feels safer.
SCENARIOS	• Scenario A: a player writes attacking "I see" statements. Gently stop them: "This is an interpretation. What did you concretely see?" Help them rewrite without judgment. • Scenario B: a player wants to use the model immediately for a real tension in the team. Guide carefully: "Is this something you actually want to address, or are you just practicing?"
PITFALLS	• "I see" statements that are actually judgments. "You do not contribute" is a judgment, not an observation. • Skipping the exercise because "they already know this." Knowing is not the same as being able to apply it under pressure.
FAQ	Q: Do I always have to use this model in real conversations? A: No. It is a practice tool. As it becomes familiar, you use the structure naturally without following it so strictly. Q: What if the other person gets angry when I address them? A: Ask calmly: "I said this because I care about our team. Can I explain what I meant?" Staying calm helps more than repeating your point.

WRAPPING UP

Questions, follow-up and closing

3 Rituals and culture promise

⌚ 10 min

EXPLAIN	Culture without rituals fades. Small, repeated actions keep culture alive, even when pressure rises. The signature symbolically and powerfully closes the track.
SAY:	<i>"Write three rituals: one before training, one after a game, one in a difficult moment. Then write one sentence saying what you contribute to the culture of this team. Sign with name and date."</i>
TIPS	- Do not ask which ritual sounds best, but which ritual is easiest to keep up for at least eight weeks. Small and doable works; ambitious and complicated does not. - Introduce the first ritual at the very next practice. Player ownership increases the chance it sticks. - Actively name each ritual for the first four weeks when you see it: "This is exactly the ritual you chose."
SCENARIOS	- Scenario A: players propose complex rituals. Help simplify: "What is the essence of this in 30 seconds?" - Scenario B: the group does not want rituals ("that feels forced"). Show a small example: "What if before every practice you name one person who did something well that week? 30 seconds, big impact."
PITFALLS	- Introducing rituals that are too complex or time-consuming. A ritual experienced as a burden disappears within two weeks. - Not actively following up on rituals. New behavior needs 6-8 weeks of support before it becomes automatic.
FAQ	Q: What if the team already forgets the ritual after a week? A: That is normal. Remind them without judgment: "We agreed to name one person before practice. We do it now." Restart without drama. Q: Who keeps track of the rituals? A: Initially you, but the aim is for players to take over. Ask who wants to take this on.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS TO ASK

- Which of the four trust questions felt most dangerous to answer honestly, and why?
- Have you ever addressed someone about their behavior? What worked and what did not?
- Which ritual would immediately change our team, even if it only takes 30 seconds?
- What do you want a new teammate to say about this group five years from now?

FOLLOW-UP IN THE COMING WEEKS

- Introduce the first ritual at the very next practice. Mention explicitly that it comes from the players themselves, not from you.
- Check the ritual agreements after four weeks: are they still active? If not, discuss this openly and without judgment.
- Use the "I see, I feel, I ask" model yourself in conversations with players. This makes it normal outside the session.
- Plan a short look-back on the track after six weeks: what changed? What did not? Plan it now.